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Reproducing the Myth:

The Distortion of Mafia History in the

Mafia Video Game Franchise

A Graduation Thesis

by

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THESIS STATEMENT

This thesis argues that the *Mafia* video game franchise distorts the documented history of the Sicilian and Italian-American mafia not by inventing falsehoods but through selective framing: the games preserve genuine fragments of the historical record, yet reframe them so that the organization's documented reality as a modern, economically driven, and politically embedded protection business recedes, and the mafia's own ideological self-image, the myth of "rustic chivalry," takes its place. This substitution occurs because the romance of honour, loyalty, and ancient Sicilian roots is more marketable and more immersive than the bureaucratic and economic reality the sources describe. The games are therefore neither faithful history nor pure fiction, but a particular kind of fiction that operates through identifiable and recurring strategies of distortion, traced here across three games depicting three eras of mafia history.

INTRODUCTION

The mafia is a pervasive presence across film, literature, and theatre. Hollywood has portrayed Irish, Mexican, and South American organized crime extensively, yet among these, one type prevails: the Italian and Italian-American mafia. From *The Godfather* to *The Sopranos*, the Italian mafia has served as the vehicle through which these stories are told, with fiction built upon fragments of historical truth, fragments that are simultaneously romanticized into mafia mythology and twisted away from the grounded reality of the mafia itself. The film industry, however, is not the only medium that has drawn on Italian mafia narratives. Toward the end of the twentieth century, a new medium emerged: the video game. As consoles and personal computers became widely accessible, audiences increasingly engaged with story-driven, cinematic games that aspired to the narrative ambition of film. Among them, one franchise emerged as central to the representation of the Italian mafia: the *Mafia* series, originally developed by Illusion Softworks (later 2K Czech), currently developed by Hangar 13, and published throughout by 2K Games.

The most important difference between video games and other media is interactivity. A game does not simply present a story to its audience; it positions the player as a participant within a digital environment composed of interconnected systems and rules. Janet Murray observes that digital environments are fundamentally "procedural," defined by "the computer's defining ability to execute a series of rules," and that these "procedural environments are appealing to us not just because they exhibit rule-generated behavior but because we can induce the behavior."[1]1 Games are, in Murray's terms, participatory rather than spectatorial. The player therefore does not passively consume the experience but acts within it, assuming the role of another person and performing that person's choices. In the *Mafia* franchise, the role on offer is that of the mafioso himself, and the experience the games construct is built upon what John Dickie describes as the mafia's "rustic chivalry" , the romantic self-image of honor, loyalty, and belonging that the organization cultivated as its own ideological self-presentation. Where a film viewer watches a fictional gangster live by this code, the player of a *Mafia* game is invited

[1] Janet H. Murray, *Hamlet on the Holodeck: The Future of Narrative in Cyberspace* (New York: Free Press, 1997), 71–74.

to live by it, swearing the oaths and enacting the loyalties that the myth prescribes.

What Dickie means by the myth of rustic chivalry is that the mafia has long presented itself not as a criminal organization but as an expression of Sicilian character - a matter of defiant pride, honor, and identity rooted in the island itself. The function of this self-image was to deny the mafia a history, a structure, and therefore any accountability: if the mafia was simply who Sicilians were, there was no organization to investigate and no leadership to prosecute. This myth became the foundation of countless mafia narratives in popular culture. The historical record, however, contradicts it at every point.

A documented history of the mafia's internal workings became possible only in the final decades of the twentieth century. Although scholars had analyzed the organization since the nineteenth century, it was the testimony of insiders - above all the pentito Tommaso Buscetta - that first exposed its structure from within. Buscetta gave this testimony to Giovanni Falcone, the investigating magistrate whose work produced the maxi-trial of the late 1980s and who was assassinated, together with his wife and his police escort, in the Capaci bombing of 1992, an attack carried out by *Cosa Nostra* itself. The grim irony is that the mafia's most violent assertion of its own power coincided with the moment at which its inner history became most fully knowable. For this thesis, John Dickie's *Cosa Nostra: A History of the Sicilian Mafia* serves as the standard synthesis of that history and as the main anchor against which the case studies measure how, and why, the games alter the historical record for their own purposes.[2]2

This thesis argues that the *Mafia* games distort the history of the mafia not by inventing falsehoods but by reproducing the mafia's own ideology - the rustic chivalry myth - in place of the documented record, because that romanticized narrative is more marketable and more immersive than the bureaucratic, economic reality the historical sources describe. This does not mean the games are pure invention. Fragments of genuine history persist within them, but they survive in distorted, selectively reworked form. The *Mafia* games are therefore neither faithful history nor pure fiction; they are a particular kind of fiction, one that operates through identifiable and recurring strategies of distortion that this thesis sets out to describe.

This thesis proceeds in two stages. It first outlines the development of the mafia in Sicily

[2]John Dickie, *Cosa Nostra: A History of the Sicilian Mafia* (London: Hodder & Stoughton, 2004). Hereafter cited as Dickie, *Cosa Nostra*.

and in America, establishing the documented record that the case studies draw upon. It then sets that record against the *Mafia* games in order to identify how and why the distortion occurs. The analysis examines *Mafia* as a depiction of the pre-war Italian-American mafia, *Mafia II* as a depiction of the post-war era, and finally *Mafia: The Old Country* as a depiction of the Sicilian roots of the organization. Throughout, the games are read not merely as entertainment but as historical texts in their own right, measured both against Dickie's history and against the scholarship on Italian-American cultural representation.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

To understand what these games inherit, one must begin with the myth they reproduce, the myth that John Dickie calls "rustic chivalry." The phrase is not his invention but a translation: it is the English rendering of *Cavalleria rusticana*, the title of the one-act opera that Pietro Mascagni first staged in Rome in 1890, a tale of jealousy, honour, and vengeance set among the peasants of Sicily that became an international sensation almost overnight. It is worth noting that Mascagni was a Tuscan who had never set foot in Sicily when he set the story to music, so that the very work which fixed the image of an ancient, honour-bound Sicily in the European imagination was itself a piece of romantic invention assembled from the outside, an early instance of the same tension between the claim of authenticity and the reality of fiction that this thesis will trace through the games. Behind the opera lay the short fiction of Giovanni Verga and, behind that, the folklore of Giuseppe Pitrè, whose reassuring definition of the mafia would later be quoted in court by mafiosi and their lawyers as a defence.[3]

What this myth proposed was that the mafia was not an organization at all but a sentiment: a defiant pride and a code of honour rooted so deeply in the Sicilian character that the two could scarcely be told apart. Its function was to deny the mafia a history and a structure, and therefore to deny it any accountability, for if the mafia was simply who Sicilians were, then there existed no organization to investigate and no leadership to prosecute. This is the romance that the games will later stage as gameplay, and it has a lineage that runs directly toward them: the music of *Cavalleria* accompanies the opening of Scorsese's *Raging Bull* and returns in the

[3]Dickie, *Cosa Nostra*, 13–16.

final act of *The Godfather Part III*, where an assassination is carried out in a Palermo opera house while the work itself is performed on stage. The myth passed from opera into cinema, and from cinema, as the case studies will show, into the video game, each medium handing the romance of rustic chivalry to the next.

Many people have assumed that the mafia had deep roots, born out of poverty and despair; the myth of rustic chivalry rests on that idea. The Italian government of the time treated it as an archaic, almost medieval inheritance. In reality, however, the mafia was a modern phenomenon, one that emerged from the regions where business and wealth were concentrated - a product of capitalist modernity rather than of backwardness.

Nineteenth-century Sicily was divided along two economic lines. The interior was given over to wheat, worked on ancient grain-producing estates, and these interior highlands were long assumed to be the mafia's birthplace. Dickie argues, however, that its true cradle was[4] "the groves of citrus fruit trees" on the coastal strip. The citrus trade in lemons and oranges was the backbone of Sicily's economic boom, especially in the post-Garibaldi era, and over the nineteenth century the industry developed into a modern business. Because citrus was far more profitable than wheat or olives, yet carried high fixed costs and was vulnerable to theft, it created a pressing demand for protection. It is worth noting, however, that the mafia's origins have been traced to two different industries: citrus and sulphur. As Paolo Buonanno, Ruben Durante, Giovanni Prarolo, and Paolo Vanin argue, where public law-enforcement institutions were weak or absent, the boom in sulphur likewise generated a demand for private, mafia-supplied protection.[5] While the debate over the relative weight of citrus and sulphur is not fully resolved, the common denominator is clear: private protection.

The early mafia thus emerged as an unnamed, illegal authority that mirrored the state: it imposed its own "taxes" - protection rackets - on commerce. But this protection was never meant for the poor and desperate. The mafia's own ideology, and the media products that reproduce it, present the organization as a protector of the weak; the historical record shows the opposite. The mafia held no political ideology of its own, only the aim of steering events

[4]Dickie, *Cosa Nostra*, 27.

[5]Paolo Buonanno, Ruben Durante, Giovanni Prarolo, and Paolo Vanin, "Poor Institutions, Rich Mines: Resource Curse in the Origins of the Sicilian Mafia," *Economic Journal* 125, no. 586 (2015): F181.

in whatever direction served its interests, and over time it murdered countless communists and trade-union leaders.

Having no genuine ideology, and having been born of capitalist enterprise, the mafia used the code of "honour" and the figure of the "man of honour" as ideological tools - devices for making its acts appear honourable. In practice it was deployed against peasant rebellions, serving both the local gabellotti (the estate leaseholders) and the state. The clearest example is the Fasci Siciliani, Sicily's first mass social movement against the estate-owners, made up of peasants and mine workers, most of them affiliated with the Socialist Party; at its height it counted more than 200,000 members across 177 leagues. As an economic crisis let the landlords shift the burden onto the working class, the Fasci demanded fairer contracts and lower taxes. To break the movement, the landlords employed the mafiosi - as in the shooting of demonstrators at the sulphur town of Lercara - and, according to one analysis, as much as 37 percent of the mafia's strength in 1900 can be attributed to its deployment against the Fasci.[6] As Lupo notes, the relationship was not one of outright opposition, nor of straightforward compatibility: the Fasci and the mafia drew on the same social milieu while offering rival models of advancement. It is precisely this ambiguity that the mafia's ideology exploits, casting itself through metaphors of "honour," "family," and a "home" for the poor - . . . the very imagery the *Mafia* franchise later seizes upon - imagery that, in the decades after unification, would cross the Atlantic to meet and merge with another body of myth then beginning to flourish in the New World.

Between 1901 and 1913, in a movement that drained close to a quarter of the island's population, some 1.1 million Sicilians emigrated, and of these roughly 800,000 settled in the United States; among the labourers, artisans, and families who made that crossing were a number of "men of honour," for whom the journey was less an escape from poverty than the extension of an existing trade. The routes along which the mafia would travel were in fact already partly in place, since Palermo and New York had long been bound together by the citrus commerce in which the organization was so deeply implicated, so that, although scattered indications of the

[6]On the Fasci and the mafia's class function see Daron Acemoglu, Giuseppe De Feo, and Giacomo Davide De Luca, "Weak States: Causes and Consequences of the Sicilian Mafia," *Review of Economic Studies* 87, no. 2 (2020): 537–581; and Dickie, *Cosa Nostra*, 132–143.

mafia in America can be found well before the turn of the century, it was only after 1900, once migration had become a mass phenomenon, that its presence on American soil grew unmistakable.

Yet this emerging Italian-American mafia did not simply carry a ready-made, "ancient" organization across the ocean and set it down intact, for, as Lupo argues, the two mafias were joined neither by an arcane legacy transported whole from provincial Sicily to urban America nor by any straightforward act of transplantation, but evolved together through a continuous process of interconnection and hybridization within a single transatlantic network whose bridge, once built, was never dissolved.[7] What crossed the ocean, in Dickie's account, was therefore not a finished institution but a method, and a method that travelled in two quite distinct ways[8]: a fast one, tied to some specific business venture such as the trade in a particular drug, in which individual mafiosi could carry the "brand" wherever they chose with the approval and assistance of the bosses back home; and a slow one, far harder to export, consisting in the patient construction of the mafia's territorial shadow-state, with its protection rackets, its political contacts, and the tacit consent both of neighbouring cosche and of sympathetic elements within the press, the police, and the local population. Because the export of that privatized form of government is so difficult an undertaking, the United States proved to be one of the rare environments into which the mafia's method could be transferred more or less wholesale, and the reason follows from everything established above: the mafia had never been a relic of a backward peasant economy but a modern capitalist enterprise, one for which America's booming and weakly governed immigrant economy offered exceptionally fertile soil.

If the mafia could carry its own method across the Atlantic, that same bridge proved far harder to cross in the other direction, by those who sought to penetrate the Sicilian mafia from outside, as the fate of Joe Petrosino shows with grim clarity: the New York Police Department detective lieutenant, after pursuing the Morello gang through the "body in the barrel" case, travelled to Palermo in 1909 to assemble an information network on Sicilian criminals with records in America; refusing the offer of an armed escort and convinced that the bribes he

[7]Salvatore Lupo, *The Two Mafias: A Transatlantic History, 1888–2008*, trans. Antony Shugaar (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2015), 2, 27.
[8]Dickie, *Cosa Nostra*, 164.

could hand out were the only protection he required, he carried into Sicily the street methods that had served him in New York, and, as Dickie observes, he "badly underestimated" the power and ruthlessness of the mafia in its homeland, where he was gunned down in a Palermo square.[9]

Why the United States should have been one of those rare environments is a question Varese has theorized: mafiosi, he argues, rarely set out to colonize new ground but arrive, more often, forced or in flight, so that transplantation takes hold only where their presence happens to coincide with the sudden appearance of a market that the state cannot govern and that no established rival already controls.[10] The textbook example of such a market arrived in 1920, when the prohibition of alcohol created, almost overnight, an enormous and entirely unregulated illegal economy, exactly the fertile, ungoverned ground on which the mafia that had already taken hold in America could expand and entrench itself.

The Prohibition era, from 1920 to 1933, rested on a dense web of alliances binding politicians, financiers, and a multi-ethnic underworld, so that the racket of the period was less a single criminal organization than a system of alliances among businessmen, labour leaders, politicians, and assorted underworld figures. Tammany Hall and its indulgent mayor, Jimmy Walker, presided over a city in which the gambling financier Arnold Rothstein, himself the son of a respectable Jewish family rather than a man of the Sicilian mafia, bankrolled the trade in liquor and narcotics and tutored a rising generation of gangsters who were as often Jewish or Irish as they were Italian; the American underworld of these years, in other words, was neither exclusively Italian nor a self-contained brotherhood of honour, but a thoroughly mixed and politically protected business.

A second and more consequential myth concerns the so-called Americanization of the mob. According to the popular story, once Charles "Lucky" Luciano had defeated the old bosses Joe Masseria and Salvatore Maranzano in 1931, a nationwide purge swept away the archaic Sicilian "greasers" and remade the mafia as a modern, Americanized corporation; yet, as Lupo shows, no trace of any such massacre survives in the police archives, in the newspapers of the day, or in the memories of the war's own veterans, so that the purge is, in his word, a legend, and

[9]Dickie, *Cosa Nostra*, 173.

[10]Federico Varese, *Mafias on the Move: How Organized Crime Conquers New Territories* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2011), 5, 9.

the supposed turning point toward Americanization it was meant to mark never actually took place.[11] Luciano was in fact the exception rather than the rule, the one boss whose family gave leading roles to non-Sicilians, while the other four New York families remained under the rule of so-called "old-type" Sicilians, and the continuity with the old world therefore persisted beneath the modernizing legend.

After the Second World War the fuel of the transatlantic mafia was no longer liquor but heroin, and the trade demonstrated that the old bridge still stood, for it was through its connection with its American counterpart, as Lupo shows, that the Sicilian mafia entered the narcotics business at all, and the networks that carried the drug from the Middle East through Sicily to the American market formed not a single, monolithic corporation but a loose web of mutually suspicious partners, run by traffickers such as the Caruana-Cuntrera clan whose power was global rather than territorial, men who moved constantly between Canada, Venezuela, Brazil, Switzerland, and Italy while only occasionally returning to the Sicilian villages whose families they nominally headed.[12] While this commerce expanded in the shadows, the mafia was being publicly rediscovered in America: the Federal Bureau of Narcotics and the televised hearings of the Kefauver Committee revived the very word "*Mafia*" in the early 1950s, the police raid on a gangsters' summit at Apalachin in 1957 returned the organization to the front pages, and in 1963 Joe Valachi, testifying before a Senate subcommittee, described from the inside a secret, ritually initiated society that he called not the *Mafia* but La *Cosa Nostra*.[13] Yet even this rediscovery produced its own distortions, since, as Ralph Blumenthal observed, the FBI's newly drawn genealogy of crime families "abruptly stopped at the Atlantic coast," blind to the Sicilian roots and transatlantic ties that bound the two mafias together, so that the official image of a monolithic American syndicate was itself a kind of myth. And it was precisely in these years, as investigators and scholars argued over what the mafia really was, that popular culture supplied its own answer: the romance Dickie calls the second fable, perfected in the Godfather era of the late 1960s and 1970s, in which the old Sicilian values of family and honour met the dark side of the American dream.[14] It is this fable, and not the bureaucratic, economic, and

[11] Lupo, *The Two Mafias*, 76–77.
[12] Lupo, *The Two Mafias*, 138, 145–148.
[13] Lupo, *The Two Mafias*, 4–6.
[14] Dickie, *Cosa Nostra*, 162.

stubbornly transatlantic reality that the sources describe, that the *Mafia* games would inherit and reproduce.

CASE STUDIES

When the entertainment industry turned to the Italian mafia, the clearest and most influential example was *The Godfather*, and as the video game industry matured into a narrative medium of its own, it inherited the same material. *Mafia*, developed by Illusion Softworks and released in 2002, was an early and ambitious example of this inheritance, and the franchise it founded has remained, across *Mafia II* and the latest entry *Mafia: The Old Country*, a series of linear, story-driven action-adventure games. This linearity matters for the present analysis: unlike strategy or role-playing titles that delegate much of the story to the player's choices, the *Mafia* games tell authored, cinematic, essentially fixed narratives, which means that every element of their representation of the mafia, from plot to dialogue to the framing of a single opening image, is a deliberate authorial decision and can be read as such. The present chapter analyzes the first game in the form in which it now circulates, the 2020 remake *Mafia: Definitive Edition* developed by Hangar 13, and notes divergences from the 2002 original where they are relevant.

MAFIA I

The game opens not with its protagonist but with a verse of scripture, an epigraph drawn from Paul's Epistle to the Romans: "We who are strong ought to bear with the failings of the weak and not to please ourselves" (Romans 15:1). Before the player has met a single character or fired a single shot, the mafia's ideology has already been stated in its purest form, and stated, moreover, in the sacralizing register of the Bible: the mafioso as the strong man whose strength exists for the sake of the weak, the protector whose violence is a form of bearing others' burdens. This is precisely the self-image that the historical record dismantles, for, as the preceding background established, the mafia's protection was never meant for the poor and desperate but was a tax imposed on commerce and a weapon deployed against the weak, against peasants, miners, and labour organizers, on behalf of those who owned the land and the groves. The epigraph thus performs, in a single quotation, the central operation this thesis traces: the sub-

stitution of the mafia's own rustic-chivalry mythology for its documented function, presented to the player as the moral frame through which the coming story is to be understood.

The game is set in Lost Heaven, a fictional American metropolis modelled on the New York and Chicago of the 1930s, and its story runs from 1930 to 1938, with an epilogue reaching into 1951. The protagonist, Thomas "Tommy" Angelo, is an ordinary taxi driver who is dragged into the world of the Salieri crime family by accident, when two of its men force him to drive them to safety, and who then rises through the family's ranks across the decade of the Great Depression. The entire narrative, however, is delivered through a frame: in 1938 Tommy sits down in a diner with Detective Norman and tells him his story, offering testimony against the Salieri family in exchange for protection. The game, in other words, is structured as a confession; everything the player experiences is the content of a mafioso's testimony to the authorities.

The frame's anachronism runs deeper than form, for the game also displays, with easy familiarity, the mafia's internal architecture: the family, its ranks, its rituals of loyalty, the very grammar of organized crime that the player is invited to learn. Yet this architecture was not public knowledge in the 1930s in which the story is set; as the background established, the organization's inner structure entered the public record only through the insider testimonies of the 1960s and after, from Valachi's hearings to Buscetta's depositions, and entered popular consciousness above all through the cinema those revelations made possible. What the game presents as the self-evident texture of the Prohibition era is, in other words, a body of post-1963 knowledge projected backwards onto the 1930s, and projected in its mythologized, Godfather-inflected form rather than in the bureaucratic form the testimonies themselves described.

The same operation governs the game's gestures toward Sicily. When Tommy visits Vincenzo, the family's armorer, to collect a weapon, Vincenzo remarks that the gun has already been used in a shooting back in Sicily, and that there is no need to ask how that affair turned out. The detail is small but exact in its function: the historical record shows that the transatlantic bridge between the two mafias was real, a working network across which men, money, and weapons moved as items of business, yet the game reworks that documented connection into something else entirely, an ancestral aura, a reminder that the violence the player wields

descends from an old and distant homeland. A genuine fragment of history, the transatlantic tie, survives in the scene, but it survives transformed: the bridge becomes a bloodline, and the business becomes an inheritance, which is precisely the "ancient roots" fallacy that the opening chapters of this thesis dismantled.

A further alteration of the historical setting concerns the multi-ethnic character of the Prohibition-era underworld. As the background established, the world in which the game takes place was populated by Jewish financiers and racketeers, Irish political machines, and Italian gangs operating side by side within a politically protected economy; Lost Heaven, by contrast, offers a war between two Italian families, Salieri and Morello, as though organized crime in 1930s America were an exclusively Italian affair. This narrowing has two causes.

The first lies in the public imagination that the entertainment industry itself had built, an imagination dominated since the 1970s by La *Cosa Nostra*: *The Godfather* films served, in effect, as a guidebook for any media production touching the mafia, supplying not only the visual and dramatic conventions of the genre but the mafia's own ideological vocabulary of *omertà* and "men of honour," so that a game made in 2002 inherited an Italian-centred mythology that had long since displaced the mixed, business-like underworld of the historical record.[15]

The second cause lies in the demands of media production itself. The documented mafia was, as this thesis has argued throughout, above all a business: a system of protection rackets, political contacts, labour racketeering, and profit-driven alliances that crossed ethnic lines whenever crossing them paid, and that bent its own "moral" rules whenever the rules obstructed the money. A business of this kind resists dramatization, for there is no tragedy in a ledger and no catharsis in a protection fee; what can be dramatized, and therefore what can be sold, is conflict between families bound by codes of honour, loyalty rewarded and betrayed, the rise and fall of men who live and die by their oaths. The two-family war of Lost Heaven is thus not a misunderstanding of the historical record but a commercial translation of it: the unmarketable reality of business is exchanged for the marketable fiction of honour, which is precisely the substitution this thesis set out in its introduction.

[15] Giulio Pitroso, "Mafia and the Representation of Italians," *Transactions of the Digital Games Research Association* 5, no. 1 (2020).

MAFIA II

The first game succeeded through its authentic environmental realism layered over partial or altered historical truths, and the second game of the franchise begins, in places, to correct some of those historical fallacies even as it introduces new ones of its own, chief among them the patriotic mafia and the mafia's American dream. *Mafia II* opens with its protagonist, Vito Scaletta, serving in the United States Army during the invasion of Italy, and in an early scene, as American and Italian forces confront one another, an old man riding atop a tank orders the Italian soldiers to lay down their arms because the war is over, a man everyone present seems to recognize: Don Calò. The moment restages one of the most popular legends about the mafia, the claim that Calogero Vizzini and the Sicilian men of honour smoothed the Allied landings of 1943, a story that Lupo, like most historians, regards as largely a myth for which no firm evidence exists.

The reason the game reaches for this legend is revealing, because the scene presents the Sicilian mafia as a power so embedded in the political order that the American government itself must treat with it, which is to say it presents the mafia, for a single cinematic moment, as precisely the shadow state that the historical sources describe. Yet this glimpse of the mafia-as-government is never developed into a theme; having used the legend to lend its organization an aura of ancient power and political weight, the game abandons the shadow-state framing entirely and spends the remainder of its story portraying the mafia as an enemy of the state, an outlaw band locked in conflict with the law, which it historically was not. The shadow state, in other words, appears only as borrowed grandeur in an opening cutscene and never as the structural truth of what the mafia is, and this selective use, invoking the mafia's governmental power to romanticize it while suppressing that same power everywhere it would demystify it, is itself an instance of the distortion this thesis traces.

The reason for this representation is, once again, the myth of honour. If the game were to portray the mafia as a power exercising control over the various branches of government, the mafia would be stripped of its rustic chivalry, the very founding fallacy on which its romantic image rests; a shadow state that bargains with senators and police chiefs cannot also be the noble outlaw band that the myth requires, and so the game suppresses the former to preserve

the latter.

The same protective myth governs the opening arc of the game. Vito tries to make an honest living, but honest labour secures nothing in so hard a town, and the only path that promises escape from poverty runs through organized crime; this is Dickie's second fable rendered as gameplay, the dark side of the American dream meeting the old Sicilian values of family and honour. Yet the irony, which the game does not acknowledge, is that these "old Sicilian values" were never in fact the inheritance of the Italian-American mafia at all: as the historical background established, the mafia was never a custodian of ancestral honour but a modern protection business, so that the very Sicilian birthright the fable invokes to ennoble Vito's choice is itself a myth, an honour code retrofitted onto an organization that the record shows to have been driven by profit rather than by any patrimony of family and honour.

Mafia II invokes, once again, the internal ban on drugs within the family. That prohibition had begun as a protective measure, a defence against informers and federal prosecution rather than a moral principle, and the crime families were never in truth wholly outside the trade; they relied on recently arrived, non-member Sicilians to handle the narcotics while preserving their own deniability. Over time, however, this pragmatic rule was reworked into an ideology the mafia told about itself, the image of honourable men who would not poison children and women, a piece of the same rustic-chivalry myth. Historically the ban held firm in Italy only until the 1960s, and in America it was honoured more in word than in deed, formally maintained while routinely broken; as Paoli shows, loyalty and honour functioned here as instruments rather than constraints, precepts with nothing solid to enforce them, ignored in daily practice above all by the family chiefs themselves.[16]

It is precisely here that the game shows the player the truth: by the closing arc, every crime family, the Falcone family included, is revealed to be in the drug business. What matters for this analysis is not whether the game depicts this accurately, which in this instance it does, but how it frames what it depicts. *Mafia II* frames the revelation as a fall, the corruption of an older and more honourable order, whereas the historical record frames the same fact as continuity, the visible surface of a profit-seeking enterprise that the honour code had only ever decorated.

[16]Letizia Paoli, *Mafia Brotherhoods: Organized Crime, Italian Style* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2003), 76–77, 116.

The distortion this thesis traces lies not in invention but in framing: what *Mafia II* presents as betrayal, the sources present as the rule, and what the game reads as the death of the old mafia, Paoli and Lupo read as the mafia being what it had always been.

Having examined these two games in accordance with their historical timespan, the pre-war world of *Mafia* and the post-war world of *Mafia II*, this thesis turns finally to the question of the mafia's birth as the franchise itself imagines it in its most recent entry, *Mafia: The Old Country*. Where the first two games inherited the mafia's American fable and projected it backwards onto the United States of the 1930s and the 1940s, this last game travels further still, to the Sicily in which the organization actually originated, and in doing so it makes explicit the claim that the earlier games only implied: that the mafia possesses ancient, rustic, honourable roots in the Sicilian soil itself.

MAFIA: OLD COUNTRY

The franchise's most recent entry was released on 7 August 2025, and it concerns the Sicilian origins both of the mafia itself and of the mafiosi who populate the earlier games. In its opening the protagonist, Enzo, is working as a carusu, one of the child labourers between roughly ten and fifteen years of age who toiled in the sulphur mines, and the choice of setting is significant, for it shows a mafia bound up with the ownership and control of the mines. This is no surprise in light of the historical scholarship: as Buonanno and his collaborators argue, the sulphur industry was one of the cradles of the organization, and it is telling that the earliest trial against the mafia, held in 1885, was directed against the Favara brotherhood, whose members were drawn largely from the sulphur towns.[17]

After the player has completed a handful of early missions, the game presents its opening credits, and one image among them is especially revealing, because it gestures toward a second school of thought on the mafia's genesis: the citrus trade. The world the game constructs is one in which lemon and orange groves and sulphur mines coexist within a single landscape, so that the two rival economic explanations of the mafia's birth, the citrus thesis associated with Dimico and his collaborators[18] and the sulphur thesis of Buonanno, are fused into one

[17] Buonanno et al., "Poor Institutions, Rich Mines," F181; see also Acemoglu, De Feo, and De Luca, "Weak States."

[18] Arcangelo Dimico, Alessia Isopi, and Ola Olsson, "Origins of the Sicilian Mafia: The Market for Lemons,"

continuous Sicilian terrain. Yet in drawing together these two economic accounts, the game omits a third and crucial dimension of the mafia's genesis: its function as a political instrument.

Policemen are visible throughout the game, and some are shown to be linked to the rival mafia family, but there is no indication anywhere of local politicians entangled with the mafiosi, no sense of the organization as the enforcement arm of those who held office. This political absence might be defended on the grounds that the Italian state was weak and its institutions barely present in turn-of-the-century Sicily; but those institutions, however weak, were not absent, and the weakness of the state was precisely the condition under which the mafia became, in the words of the prosecutor Diego Tajani, an instrument of local government rather than its enemy.[19] A weak state did not remove the mafia from politics; it embedded the mafia within them.

Only a single line in the entire game touches on these political relationships. After a mission to break up a strike, Luca remarks that Don Torrisi, the head of the family to which the player's character belongs, takes a dim view of strikes, and recalls that back in the 1890s the Fasci Siciliani and their unions had been everywhere. In that brief exchange the game brushes against the documented historical reality, the mafia's role as the violent suppressor of the peasant movement, only to pass over it as quickly as it is raised.

Although the game is set between 1904 and 1907, the strikes and the mafia's deployment by those who held local power remain visible within it. Here the work of Acemoglu and his collaborators, which bridges the competing schools of origin, becomes directly relevant: they argue that it was precisely the suppression of the Fasci Siciliani that allowed the mafia to spread outward into the rural interior, and it is exactly this rural Sicily that the game depicts[20], a world of villages and estates rather than of the urban city, with Palermo itself appearing only once, for a single mission. The game's geography, in other words, is the geography of the mafia's rural expansion that the historical scholarship describes.

A further trace of the mafia's documented origins appears in the figure of Baron Raffaele Fontanella. The Baron is an aristocrat who owns much of the Valle Dorata, the fictional region

Journal of Economic History 77, no. 4 (2017): 1083–1115.

[19]Diego Tajani, quoted in Dickie, *Cosa Nostra*, 73.

[20]Acemoglu, De Feo, and De Luca, "Weak States," 537–581.

in which the game takes place, and both the Torrisi and the rival Spadaro families conduct their business on his lands, the Torrisi in particular carrying out their dirty work across the Valle Dorata. This arrangement points toward a different account of the mafia's genesis, the post-feudal theory: not the survival of feudalism but its dissolution, the moment at which the great estates passed into a landscape of leaseholding and private enterprise, created the conditions in which a new class turned to the mafia to control land and labour. The aristocrat remains on the scene, yet the real economic and coercive power now operates through the families who work his land.

Although much of the relevant literature exists only in Italian, this thesis relies here on the work of Anton Blok, whose study of a Sicilian village offers the clearest English-language account of the post-feudal origins of the mafia. Following the reforms that began in 1812, the old feudal estates were dismantled and their lands brought into a market in private property; the result was a class of absentee barons who, preferring the aristocratic life of the cities, leased their holdings to a rising stratum of managers known as gabellotti. It was from this stratum, Blok argues, that the mafiosi emerged, the leaseholders and overseers who controlled land and labour through violence and who rose, in his phrase, as violent peasant entrepreneurs.[21] It is worth noting that the game frames both the Torrisi and the Spadaro families in precisely this way, as gabellotti operating the estates of an aristocrat rather than as landowners in their own right, so that the post-feudal account of the mafia's birth is not merely gestured at but built into the very structure of the families the player encounters.

Taken together, these elements show that *Mafia: The Old Country* does not reduce the mafia's genesis to a single explanation but draws the competing schools into one composite portrait, representing the citrus economy, the sulphur mines, and the post-feudal estate system with considerable success, and failing in only one respect: the absence of the local politicians who, in the historical record, were inseparable from the organization's power.

Two further details of the game carry genuine historical weight. The first is the practice the game calls tooth talking, the coded ritual by which one mafioso recognized another. A Palermo Chief of Police report of 1875 records this very recognition code: a made man would announce

[21] Anton Blok, *The Mafia of a Sicilian Village, 1860–1960: A Study of Violent Peasant Entrepreneurs* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1974), 75.

to a stranger, while pointing to a canine tooth, that his tooth was hurting him, and if the other was himself a man of honour he would reply that his hurt too, after which the exchange would proceed by degrees to establish where, when, and in whose presence each had been initiated.[22] What the game presents as an item of exotic local colour was in reality a practical instrument of secrecy, a counter-measure against infiltration in a world where membership could never be openly declared.

The second is the knife fighting that the game adapts into one of its central combat mechanics. Here too there is a historical foundation, for the knife was both the everyday weapon and the emblem of an honour culture in nineteenth-century Sicily, the culture of the rustic duel that *Cavalleria rusticana* had set to music; yet that culture of bladed honour was not peculiar to the mafia but common to the Sicilian peasantry at large, so that to make it the signature of mafia violence is once again to dress the organization in the borrowed garments of a regional tradition, when the documented reality of mafia killing was less the open duel than the instrumental execution, the shot delivered from behind in broad daylight.

CONCLUSION

The *Mafia* franchise occupies a distinctive position in the representation of organized crime, telling the story of the mafia not through the spectator's distance of film but through the interactive and linear form of the video game. At first glance these games may appear to be simple, movie-inspired entertainments, yet beneath that surface lie deliberate authorial decisions that this thesis has sought to expose, and behind those decisions a consistent logic governing how the games handle the historical record.

Across the three games examined here, the distortion of mafia history has been shown to operate not through outright invention but through framing: the games preserve genuine fragments of the historical record and embed them within an authentic environmental design, yet they reframe those fragments so that the documented reality recedes and the mafia's own mythology takes its place. The authenticity of the environment is essential to this operation, because it makes the player feel the era and its needs, and that felt authenticity lends credibility

[22] Dickie, *Cosa Nostra*, 46–47.

to the mythology layered over it. *Mafia: The Old Country* illustrates the method with particular clarity, gathering the sulphur mines, the citrus groves, and the slopes of Etna, features scattered across the whole of Sicily, into a single composed region that lets the player experience the island as a coherent and intimate world.

Most importantly, all three games rest upon the mafia's own ideology, the myth of rustic chivalry, which can be traced from the first game to the last: in the scriptural epigraph that opens *Mafia*, in the second fable of family and honour that structures *Mafia II*, and in the ancient Sicilian roots that *Mafia: The Old Country* sets out to dramatize. The recurring strategies through which this myth displaces the record, the substitution of honour for economic function, the inversion of the mafia's class role, the preservation of period appearance over economic substance, the purification of a multi-ethnic and politically embedded underworld into a closed world of Italian honour, and the re-mystification of the very confessions that once demystified the organization, are not incidental choices but the consistent grammar of the franchise.

These distortions matter beyond the narrow question of how a game handles history, for the mafia's ideology is bound up with the representation of an identity and even of a nation. The romanticized image a game reproduces is never only a matter of historical accuracy; it touches the self-understanding of a people, which is why *Mafia II* met with protest for what was seen as a misrepresentation of Sicilian culture and its roots. To reproduce the mafia's myth is also to make a claim, however unintended, about Sicily and about Italian and Italian-American identity.

Finally, the study of historical representation in games points beyond the games themselves, toward the discipline of history. It suggests that history need not remain a document-based field alone, and that the interactive, constructed, and commercially shaped historical worlds of video games are themselves objects worthy of careful analysis. Building a rigorous methodology for reading historical games is a demanding task, but it is an increasingly necessary one, and the body of scholarship devoted to it continues to grow.

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